25 Most Common French Verbs

Each verb shows the **present tense**, plus the "I" form in the **past (passé composé)** and **future (futur simple)**, and an example sentence.

> Pronunciation uses English-style respelling, not IPA. Read it as if it were English, using the key on the next page.

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Pronunciation key

Spelling	Sounds like
zh	the "s" in *measure* (French **j** / soft **g**)
uh	the "a" in *about*
ew	French **u**: say "ee" with your lips rounded like "oo"
N (capital)	nasal vowel: hum the vowel through your nose, don't say the "n"
ahN	nasal *an* / *en* (as in *France*)
ohN	nasal *on* (as in *bon*)
aN	nasal *in* / *ain* / *ien* (as in *vin*)
uhN	nasal *un* (as in *un*)
r	French throaty "r", made at the back of the throat

Tips: final consonants are usually silent (*parlent* = "parl"). **on** ("we/one") always uses the *il/elle* form.

1. être — to be *(eh-truh)*

Lesson 1 · The Essentials

French	Pronunciation	English
je suis	*zhuh swee*	I am
tu es	*tew eh*	you are
il/elle est	*eel/el eh*	he/she is
nous sommes	*noo sum*	we are
vous êtes	*voo zet*	you (pl./formal) are
ils/elles sont	*eel/el sohN*	they are

Past **j'ai été** *(zhay ay-tay)* — I was / have been
Future **je serai** *(zhuh suh-ray)* — I will be
Sentence **Je suis fatigué(e) aujourd'hui.** *(zhuh swee fah-tee-gay oh-zhoor-dwee)* — *I am tired today.*

2. avoir — to have *(ah-vwahr)*

Lesson 1 · The Essentials

French	Pronunciation	English
j'ai	*zhay*	I have
tu as	*tew ah*	you have
il/elle a	*eel/el ah*	he/she has
nous avons	*noo zah-vohN*	we have
vous avez	*voo zah-vay*	you have
ils/elles ont	*eel/el zohN*	they have

Past **j'ai eu** *(zhay ew)* — I had
Future **j'aurai** *(zhoh-ray)* — I will have
Sentence **J'ai deux frères.** *(zhay duh frair)* — *I have two brothers.*

3. aller — to go *(ah-lay)*

Lesson 1 · The Essentials

French	Pronunciation	English
je vais	*zhuh veh*	I go
tu vas	*tew vah*	you go
il/elle va	*eel/el vah*	he/she goes
nous allons	*noo zah-lohN*	we go
vous allez	*voo zah-lay*	you go
ils/elles vont	*eel/el vohN*	they go

Past **je suis allé(e)** *(zhuh swee zah-lay)* — I went
Future **j'irai** *(zhee-ray)* — I will go
Sentence **Nous allons au marché samedi.** *(noo zah-lohN oh mar-shay sahm-dee)* — *We are going to the market on Saturday.*

4. faire — to do / to make *(fair)*

Lesson 1 · The Essentials

French	Pronunciation	English
je fais	*zhuh feh*	I do
tu fais	*tew feh*	you do
il/elle fait	*eel/el feh*	he/she does
nous faisons	*noo fuh-zohN*	we do
vous faites	*voo fet*	you do
ils/elles font	*eel/el fohN*	they do

Past **j'ai fait** *(zhay feh)* — I did
Future **je ferai** *(zhuh fuh-ray)* — I will do
Sentence **Il fait beau aujourd'hui.** *(eel feh boh oh-zhoor-dwee)* — *The weather is nice today.*

5. dire — to say / to tell *(deer)*

Lesson 1 · The Essentials

French	Pronunciation	English
je dis	*zhuh dee*	I say
tu dis	*tew dee*	you say
il/elle dit	*eel/el dee*	he/she says
nous disons	*noo dee-zohN*	we say
vous dites	*voo deet*	you say
ils/elles disent	*eel/el deez*	they say

Past **j'ai dit** *(zhay dee)* — I said
Future **je dirai** *(zhuh dee-ray)* — I will say
Sentence **Elle dit toujours la vérité.** *(el dee too-zhoor lah vay-ree-tay)* — *She always tells the truth.*

6. pouvoir — can / to be able to *(poo-vwahr)*

Lesson 4 · Wanting, Needing, Knowing

French	Pronunciation	English
je peux	*zhuh puh*	I can
tu peux	*tew puh*	you can
il/elle peut	*eel/el puh*	he/she can
nous pouvons	*noo poo-vohN*	we can
vous pouvez	*voo poo-vay*	you can
ils/elles peuvent	*eel/el puhv*	they can

Past **j'ai pu** *(zhay pew)* — I could / was able to
Future **je pourrai** *(zhuh poo-ray)* — I will be able to
Sentence **Est-ce que je peux entrer ?** *(es-kuh zhuh puh ahN-tray)* — *Can I come in?*

7. vouloir — to want *(voo-lwahr)*

Lesson 4 · Wanting, Needing, Knowing

French	Pronunciation	English
je veux	*zhuh vuh*	I want
tu veux	*tew vuh*	you want
il/elle veut	*eel/el vuh*	he/she wants
nous voulons	*noo voo-lohN*	we want
vous voulez	*voo voo-lay*	you want
ils/elles veulent	*eel/el vuhl*	they want

Past **j'ai voulu** *(zhay voo-lew)* — I wanted
Future **je voudrai** *(zhuh voo-dray)* — I will want
Sentence **Je veux apprendre le français.** *(zhuh vuh zah-prahN-druh luh frahN-seh)* — *I want to learn French.*

> **Polite tip:** say **je voudrais** (zhuh voo-dreh) = "I would like" when ordering.

8. savoir — to know (a fact / how to) *(sah-vwahr)*

Lesson 4 · Wanting, Needing, Knowing

French	Pronunciation	English
je sais	*zhuh seh*	I know
tu sais	*tew seh*	you know
il/elle sait	*eel/el seh*	he/she knows
nous savons	*noo sah-vohN*	we know
vous savez	*voo sah-vay*	you know
ils/elles savent	*eel/el sahv*	they know

Past **j'ai su** *(zhay sew)* — I knew / found out
Future **je saurai** *(zhuh soh-ray)* — I will know
Sentence **Je ne sais pas.** *(zhuh nuh seh pah)* — *I don't know.*

9. voir — to see *(vwahr)*

Lesson 3 · Everyday Actions

French	Pronunciation	English
je vois	*zhuh vwah*	I see
tu vois	*tew vwah*	you see
il/elle voit	*eel/el vwah*	he/she sees
nous voyons	*noo vwah-yohN*	we see
vous voyez	*voo vwah-yay*	you see
ils/elles voient	*eel/el vwah*	they see

Past **j'ai vu** *(zhay vew)* — I saw
Future **je verrai** *(zhuh veh-ray)* — I will see
Sentence **Je vois la tour Eiffel d'ici.** *(zhuh vwah lah toor eh-fel dee-see) — I can see the Eiffel Tower from here.*

10. venir — to come *(vuh-neer)*

Lesson 5 · Coming, Going, Taking

French	Pronunciation	English
je viens	*zhuh vyaN*	I come
tu viens	*tew vyaN*	you come
il/elle vient	*eel/el vyaN*	he/she comes
nous venons	*noo vuh-nohN*	we come
vous venez	*voo vuh-nay*	you come
ils/elles viennent	*eel/el vyen*	they come

Past **je suis venu(e)** *(zhuh swee vuh-new)* — I came
Future **je viendrai** *(zhuh vyaN-dray)* — I will come
Sentence **Tu viens avec nous ?** *(tew vyaN ah-vek noo) — Are you coming with us?*

11. devoir — must / to have to *(duh-vwahr)*

Lesson 4 · Wanting, Needing, Knowing

French	Pronunciation	English
je dois	*zhuh dwah*	I must
tu dois	*tew dwah*	you must
il/elle doit	*eel/el dwah*	he/she must
nous devons	*noo duh-vohN*	we must
vous devez	*voo duh-vay*	you must
ils/elles doivent	*eel/el dwahv*	they must

Past **j'ai dû** *(zhay dew)* — I had to
Future **je devrai** *(zhuh duh-vray)* — I will have to
Sentence **Je dois partir maintenant.** *(zhuh dwah par-teer maNt-nahN) — I have to leave now.*

12. prendre — to take *(prahN-druh)*

Lesson 5 · Coming, Going, Taking

French	Pronunciation	English
je prends	*zhuh prahN*	I take
tu prends	*tew prahN*	you take
il/elle prend	*eel/el prahN*	he/she takes
nous prenons	*noo pruh-nohN*	we take
vous prenez	*voo pruh-nay*	you take
ils/elles prennent	*eel/el pren*	they take

Past **j'ai pris** *(zhay pree)* — I took
Future **je prendrai** *(zhuh prahN-dray)* — I will take
Sentence **Je prends le métro tous les matins.** *(zhuh prahN luh may-troh too lay mah-taN) — I take the metro every morning.*

13. mettre — to put / to put on *(meh-truh)*

Lesson 5 · Coming, Going, Taking

French	Pronunciation	English
je mets	*zhuh meh*	I put
tu mets	*tew meh*	you put
il/elle met	*eel/el meh*	he/she puts
nous mettons	*noo meh-tohN*	we put
vous mettez	*voo meh-tay*	you put
ils/elles mettent	*eel/el met*	they put

Past **j'ai mis** *(zhay mee)* — I put
Future **je mettrai** *(zhuh meh-tray)* — I will put
Sentence **Elle met son manteau.** *(el meh sohN mahN-toh) — She is putting on her coat.*

14. donner — to give *(doh-nay)*

Lesson 2 · Regular -er Verbs

French	Pronunciation	English
je donne	*zhuh dun*	I give
tu donnes	*tew dun*	you give
il/elle donne	*eel/el dun*	he/she gives
nous donnons	*noo doh-nohN*	we give
vous donnez	*voo doh-nay*	you give
ils/elles donnent	*eel/el dun*	they give

Past **j'ai donné** *(zhay doh-nay)* — I gave
Future **je donnerai** *(zhuh dun-ray)* — I will give
Sentence **Je donne un livre à mon ami.** *(zhuh dun uhN leevr ah moh-nah-mee) — I am giving a book to my friend.*

15. parler — to speak / to talk *(par-lay)*

Lesson 2 · Regular -er Verbs

French	Pronunciation	English
je parle	*zhuh parl*	I speak
tu parles	*tew parl*	you speak
il/elle parle	*eel/el parl*	he/she speaks
nous parlons	*noo par-lohN*	we speak
vous parlez	*voo par-lay*	you speak
ils/elles parlent	*eel/el parl*	they speak

Past **j'ai parlé** *(zhay par-lay)* — I spoke
Future **je parlerai** *(zhuh par-luh-ray)* — I will speak
Sentence **Vous parlez anglais ?** *(voo par-lay zahN-gleh)* — *Do you speak English?*

16. aimer — to like / to love *(eh-may)*

Lesson 2 · Regular -er Verbs

French	Pronunciation	English
j'aime	*zhem*	I like
tu aimes	*tew em*	you like
il/elle aime	*eel/el em*	he/she likes
nous aimons	*noo zeh-mohN*	we like
vous aimez	*voo zeh-may*	you like
ils/elles aiment	*eel/el zem*	they like

Past **j'ai aimé** *(zhay eh-may)* — I liked
Future **j'aimerai** *(zhem-ray)* — I will like
Sentence **J'aime le chocolat.** *(zhem luh shoh-koh-lah)* — *I like chocolate.*

17. trouver — to find *(troo-vay)*

Lesson 2 · Regular -er Verbs

French	Pronunciation	English
je trouve	*zhuh troov*	I find
tu trouves	*tew troov*	you find
il/elle trouve	*eel/el troov*	he/she finds
nous trouvons	*noo troo-vohN*	we find
vous trouvez	*voo troo-vay*	you find
ils/elles trouvent	*eel/el troov*	they find

Past **j'ai trouvé** *(zhay troo-vay)* — I found
Future **je trouverai** *(zhuh troov-ray)* — I will find
Sentence **Je ne trouve pas mes clés.** *(zhuh nuh troov pah may klay)* — *I can't find my keys.*

18. passer — to pass / to spend (time) *(pah-say)*

Lesson 3 · Everyday Actions

French	Pronunciation	English
je passe	*zhuh pahs*	I pass
tu passes	*tew pahs*	you pass
il/elle passe	*eel/el pahs*	he/she passes
nous passons	*noo pah-sohN*	we pass
vous passez	*voo pah-say*	you pass
ils/elles passent	*eel/el pahs*	they pass

Past **j'ai passé** *(zhay pah-say)* — I spent / passed
Future **je passerai** *(zhuh pahs-ray)* — I will pass
Sentence **Nous passons les vacances en Italie.** *(noo pah-sohN lay vah-kahNs ahN nee-tah-lee)* — *We are spending the holidays in Italy.*

19. penser — to think *(pahN-say)*

Lesson 3 · Everyday Actions

French	Pronunciation	English
je pense	*zhuh pahNs*	I think
tu penses	*tew pahNs*	you think
il/elle pense	*eel/el pahNs*	he/she thinks
nous pensons	*noo pahN-sohN*	we think
vous pensez	*voo pahN-say*	you think
ils/elles pensent	*eel/el pahNs*	they think

Past **j'ai pensé** *(zhay pahN-say)* — I thought
Future **je penserai** *(zhuh pahNs-ray)* — I will think
Sentence **Je pense à toi.** *(zhuh pahNs ah twah)* — *I'm thinking of you.*

20. croire — to believe *(krwahr)*

Lesson 3 · Everyday Actions

French	Pronunciation	English
je crois	*zhuh krwah*	I believe
tu crois	*tew krwah*	you believe
il/elle croit	*eel/el krwah*	he/she believes
nous croyons	*noo krwah-yohN*	we believe
vous croyez	*voo krwah-yay*	you believe
ils/elles croient	*eel/el krwah*	they believe

Past **j'ai cru** *(zhay krew)* — I believed
Future **je croirai** *(zhuh krwah-ray)* — I will believe
Sentence **Je crois qu'il va pleuvoir.** *(zhuh krwah keel vah pluh-vwahr)* — *I think it's going to rain.*

21. connaître — to know (a person / place) *(koh-neh-truh)*

Lesson 4 · Wanting, Needing, Knowing

French	Pronunciation	English
je connais	*zhuh koh-neh*	I know
tu connais	*tew koh-neh*	you know
il/elle connaît	*eel/el koh-neh*	he/she knows
nous connaissons	*noo koh-neh-sohN*	we know
vous connaissez	*voo koh-neh-say*	you know
ils/elles connaissent	*eel/el koh-nes*	they know

Past **j'ai connu** *(zhay koh-new)* — I knew / met
Future **je connaîtrai** *(zhuh koh-neh-tray)* — I will know
Sentence **Tu connais Marie ?** *(tew koh-neh mah-ree)* — *Do you know Marie?*

> **Tip:** **savoir** = know a fact or how to do something; **connaître** = be familiar with a person or place.

22. partir — to leave *(par-teer)*

Lesson 5 · Coming, Going, Taking

French	Pronunciation	English
je pars	*zhuh par*	I leave
tu pars	*tew par*	you leave
il/elle part	*eel/el par*	he/she leaves
nous partons	*noo par-tohN*	we leave
vous partez	*voo par-tay*	you leave
ils/elles partent	*eel/el part*	they leave

Past **je suis parti(e)** *(zhuh swee par-tee)* — I left
Future **je partirai** *(zhuh par-tee-ray)* — I will leave
Sentence **Le train part à huit heures.** *(luh traN par ah wee tuhr)* — *The train leaves at eight o'clock.*

23. comprendre — to understand *(kohN-prahN-druh)*

Lesson 5 · Coming, Going, Taking

French	Pronunciation	English
je comprends	*zhuh kohN-prahN*	I understand
tu comprends	*tew kohN-prahN*	you understand
il/elle comprend	*eel/el kohN-prahN*	he/she understands
nous comprenons	*noo kohN-pruh-nohN*	we understand
vous comprenez	*voo kohN-pruh-nay*	you understand
ils/elles comprennent	*eel/el kohN-pren*	they understand

Past **j'ai compris** *(zhay kohN-pree)* — I understood
Future **je comprendrai** *(zhuh kohN-prahN-dray)* — I will understand
Sentence **Je ne comprends pas. Pouvez-vous répéter ?** *(zhuh nuh kohN-prahN pah. poo-vay voo ray-pay-tay)* — *I don't understand. Can you repeat?*

24. demander — to ask *(duh-mahN-day)*

Lesson 3 · Everyday Actions

French	Pronunciation	English
je demande	*zhuh duh-mahNd*	I ask
tu demandes	*tew duh-mahNd*	you ask
il/elle demande	*eel/el duh-mahNd*	he/she asks
nous demandons	*noo duh-mahN-dohN*	we ask
vous demandez	*voo duh-mahN-day*	you ask
ils/elles demandent	*eel/el duh-mahNd*	they ask

Past **j'ai demandé** *(zhay duh-mahN-day)* — I asked
Future **je demanderai** *(zhuh duh-mahN-duh-ray)* — I will ask
Sentence **Je demande le chemin à un passant.** *(zhuh duh-mahNd luh shuh-maN ah uhN pah-sahN)* — *I ask a passerby for directions.*

25. manger — to eat *(mahN-zhay)*

Lesson 2 · Regular -er Verbs

French	Pronunciation	English
je mange	*zhuh mahNzh*	I eat
tu manges	*tew mahNzh*	you eat
il/elle mange	*eel/el mahNzh*	he/she eats
nous mangeons	*noo mahN-zhohN*	we eat
vous mangez	*voo mahN-zhay*	you eat
ils/elles mangent	*eel/el mahNzh*	they eat

Past **j'ai mangé** *(zhay mahN-zhay)* — I ate
Future **je mangerai** *(zhuh mahNzh-ray)* — I will eat
Sentence **On mange ensemble ce soir ?** *(ohN mahNzh ahN-sahN-bluh suh swahr)* — *Shall we eat together tonight?*

> **Tip:** *nous mang**e**ons* keeps the extra "e" so the g stays soft.

Quick grammar notes

- **Regular -er verbs** (parler, aimer, donner, trouver, passer, penser, demander, manger) all follow the same pattern: *-e, -es, -e, -ons, -ez, -ent*. The *je, tu, il, ils* forms sound identical.
- **Liaison:** a normally silent final consonant is pronounced when the next word starts with a vowel: *vous‿avez* (voo zah-vay), *ils‿ont* (eel zohN).
- **Past tense with être:** movement verbs like *aller, venir, partir* use **être** instead of avoir (*je suis allé*), and the past participle agrees with the subject (*elle est allée*).
- **Negation:** wrap the verb with **ne ... pas**: *Je **ne** parle **pas** espagnol.* In casual speech, the *ne* is often dropped.